SUZU TRAVELS · PRIVATE TOUR OF INDIA

South India tour — 12 days: Mahabalipuram, Thanjavur, Madurai, Thekkady, backwaters and Fort Kochi

Tamil Nadu's great temples, then Kerala's spice hills and a houseboat night — a sample plan we build from; every night can move.

Day by day

DAY 1 — **Arrive Chennai → Mahabalipuram**

Your driver meets you at Chennai airport (name, photo and car number shared with you before the trip). Rather than staying in the city, we drive south along the coast to Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram) — quieter, by the sea, and the reason most travellers come this way.

DAY 2 — **Mahabalipuram: the Pallava coast**

A UNESCO World Heritage Site carved out of rock by the Pallava kings in the 7th and 8th centuries: the rathas (temples shaped like chariots), cave shrines, the giant open-air relief known as the Descent of the Ganges or Arjuna's Penance, and the Shore Temple above the waves. Go early, before the heat and the crowds.

DAY 3 — **Mahabalipuram → Puducherry**

Further down the coast to Puducherry, 162 km (101 mi) south of Chennai. The old French quarter by the seafront promenade is a grid of straight, quiet streets lined with colonial buildings, some from the 18th century. An afternoon on foot, an evening by the sea.

DAY 4 — **Puducherry → Thanjavur**

A long drive day inland to Thanjavur, the Chola capital. Arrive in time for the Brihadisvara (Big) Temple in the late-afternoon light: begun by the Chola king Rajaraja I around 1003–1004 and consecrated in 1009–1010, it is still a living temple more than a thousand years later.

DAY 5 — **Thanjavur and Darasuram**

The Big Temple again in the morning, then the Airavatesvara temple at Darasuram with its 24 m (79 ft) tower and fine stone carving. Together with Gangaikondacholapuram (completed in 1035) they form UNESCO's "Great Living Chola Temples" — Thanjavur was listed in 1987, the other two added in 2004.

DAY 6 — **Thanjavur → Madurai**

South to Madurai, a city with references going back to the 3rd century BC and called "the city that never sleeps". The Meenakshi Amman Temple has 14 gopuram towers of 45–50 m (148–164 ft) and a hall of a thousand sculpted pillars. Tamil Nadu Tourism lists opening hours of 6:00 am–12:30 pm and 4:00–9:00 pm — we check them on the day. The evening, when the temple is busiest, is the time to go.

DAY 7 — **Madurai → Thekkady**

Across the Western Ghats into Kerala: about 136 km (85 mi) from Madurai airport up to Thekkady, at 900–1,800 m (2,950–5,900 ft). The air cools, the slopes turn to cardamom, pepper, vanilla, cinnamon, tea and coffee. A spice-garden walk in the afternoon.

DAY 8 **Thekkady: Periyar Tiger Reserve**

The reserve covers 777 sq km (300 sq mi) of forest around a 26 sq km (10 sq mi) lake. A two-hour boat trip, run by the Kerala Tourism Development Corporation, is the classic way to watch elephants, gaur, sambar and otters from a safe distance. Tigers are rarely seen — we never promise one.

DAY 9 **Thekkady → the backwaters, houseboat night**

125 km (78 mi) west, about 3 hours, to Alappuzha. Board a kettuvallam, a traditional rice barge rebuilt as a houseboat with bedrooms, a living deck and a kitchen; the crew cooks lunch, dinner and breakfast on board. The boat moors for the night on a network of canals, rivers and lakes stretching over 900 km (560 mi).

DAY 10 **Backwaters → Fort Kochi**

Breakfast on the water, then about an hour north (62 km / 39 mi) to Kochi. Fort Kochi, 10 km (6 mi) from Ernakulam town, is the place to slow down: the Chinese fishing nets, standing for over five centuries, at sunset.

DAY 11 **Fort Kochi and Mattancherry**

On foot and by car: St. Francis Church — India's oldest European church — Santa Cruz Basilica, Mattancherry Palace and the Jewish Synagogue. In the evening, a Kathakali performance; arrive early to watch the make-up.

DAY 12 **Fly out of Kochi**

To Cochin International Airport, 82.8 km (51 mi) and about 2 hours from Alappuzha, less from Fort Kochi. Flying on to Delhi for the Golden Triangle, or home? We time the drive around your flight, with a margin.

What is included — and what is not

- **Included.** Private air-conditioned car and the same English-speaking driver for all 12 days, fuel, tolls, parking and state taxes; 10 hotel nights with breakfast in the tier you choose; 1 houseboat night with all meals on board; airport pick-up in Chennai and drop at Kochi.
- **Not included.** International and domestic flights, the India e-Visa, entry tickets (monuments, the Periyar boat, Kathakali), lunches and dinners off the boat, tips. We can pre-book tickets and local guides at the big temples in the same quote.
- **Cars.** Sedan for 2–3 travellers, SUV for 4–6, a minibus for groups. The ghat road up to Thekkady is narrow and winding — we use SUVs there for families.
- **How South India is run.** Our team runs North India from Himachal; in Tamil Nadu and Kerala we arrange the car, hotels and houseboat with local operators we have worked with, and stay your single point of contact from the first message to the airport drop. Your driver's name, photo and car number are shared with you before the trip.

Prices

South India — 12 days / 11 nights (this itinerary)	**on request**	Private car and driver throughout, 10 hotel nights with breakfast, 1 houseboat night with meals, airport pick-up in Chennai and drop at Kochi; tickets and guides on request

Golden Triangle — 4 days (Delhi, Agra, Jaipur)	**from US$299**	Per person, two sharing: private air-conditioned car and driver, hotels with breakfast, airport pick-up and drop, local guides at the main monuments

Prices are per person in US dollars, indicative, and confirmed on your quote. You receive a day-by-day plan with a US-dollar total and what it covers before you pay anything.

How booking works

20% deposit locks your dates and price; full refund if cancelled within 48 hours of paying; balance before the trip; pay by card via Razorpay (international cards accepted) or PayPal.

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